many Rajput kingdoms were at war, as much with each other as with the Mughals. But Akbar ‘did not give heed’;[27] and who knows, perhaps it was God who nudged him to go, for it was on this trip that Akbar not only formed one of the most fruitful spiritual associations of his life, but also agreed to a marriage that would transform the very face of his dynasty.

It was en route to Ajmer that Akbar met Raja Bihari Mal Kachhwaha again. Five years had passed since the Rajput’s brave showing at Akbar’s court, and the raja’s fortunes had declined in the interim. For all that Bihari Mal may have impressed Akbar, it was a rival of his called Suja who had managed an alliance with Akbar’s brother-in-law, Sharafuddin, who governed this area as independently as Adham had hoped to rule Malwa. Suja, therefore, occupied the Kachhwaha throne, while Bihari Mal ‘had taken refuge in the folds of the hills’,[28] forced to pay Suja tribute and let him keep his son hostage. At the moment, therefore, the raja’s situation ‘was by no means enviable’, as a modern historian writes, ‘but it improved rather unexpectedly . . .’[29]

Seeing that Akbar was travelling through his land, and remembering, perhaps, the padishah’s friendliness from some years ago, Raja Bihari Mal sent him a message, asking for an audience.

Akbar agreed. Not only that. A few days later, when Akbar and the Rajput king met near Bihari Mal’s capital, Amber,[30] Akbar also agreed to give him back his hostage and his throne, and to marry his daughter.

It doesn’t seem to have taken much for the raja to bring Akbar to his side. Abul Fazl implies that the padishah made up his mind when he saw how people fled at his advance through Rajasthan. ‘We have no other intention than to do good to all mankind,’ he had said in dismay. ‘What can be the reason of the flight of those people?’ Clearly, he continued, they were reacting to the ‘oppression they have undergone’. Sharafuddin liked to extract obedience through fear; this was not Akbar’s way.

Sometime between his gallop to Malwa and this meeting in Amber, Akbar had also ridden a short distance east, towards Ali Quli Shaibani in Jaunpur and all his unsettled dues. Ali Quli, cleverer than Adham, had hurried to meet Akbar on his way and handed over a substantial bounty. Ajmer was Akbar’s third excursion into a commander’s ‘fief’ in nine months; and it’s possible that the restoration of Bihari Mal and the marriage to his daughter